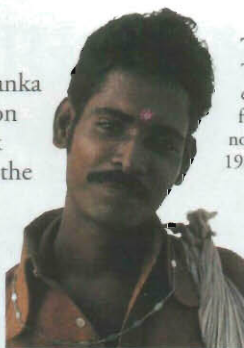


Sri Lanka

 Known as Ceylon since 1796, Sri Lanka adopted a new name and constitution in 1972. It is separated from India by the Palk Strait, and is made up of one large island and the several coral islets of Adam's Bridge. In 1960, Sri Lanka became the world's first nation to choose a woman as prime minister, Sirimavo Bandaranaike. Since 1983, civil war has raged between the Sinhalese, who rule the government, and the Tamils, who are fighting for independence.



Tamils

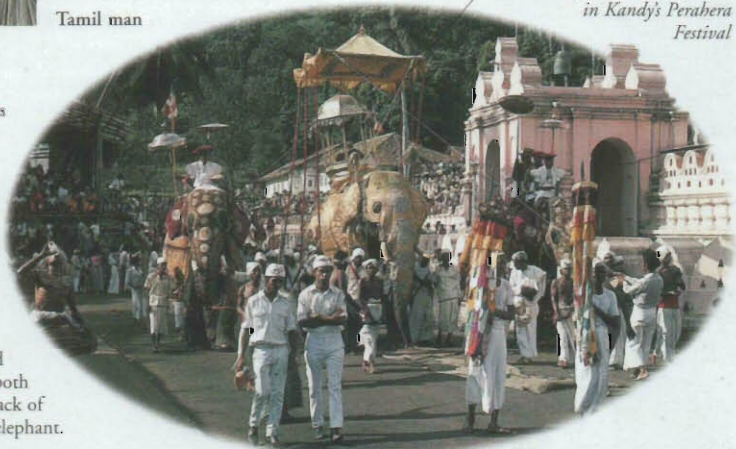
The Tamils, a mainly Hindu minority ethnic group, have been campaigning for an independent state in the northern peninsula of Jaffna since the 1980s. They object to the control of the government by the majority Sinhalese, most of whom are Buddhist. The Tamil Tigers, a ruthless guerrilla group, have fought many fierce battles in which up to 50,000 people have been killed.

Tamil man

SRI LANKA FACTS

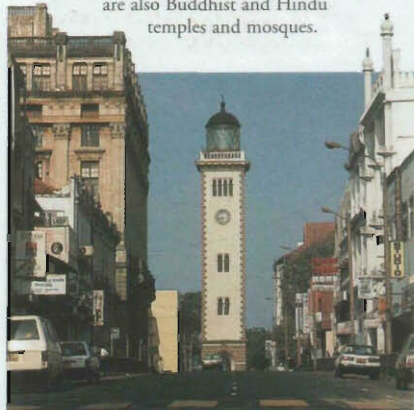
CAPITAL CITY	Colombo
AREA	65,610 sq km (25,332 sq miles)
POPULATION	18,800,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Sinhala, Tamil
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Buddhist, Hindu
CURRENCY	Sri Lankan rupee

Procession of decorated elephants in Kandy's Perahera Festival



Colombo

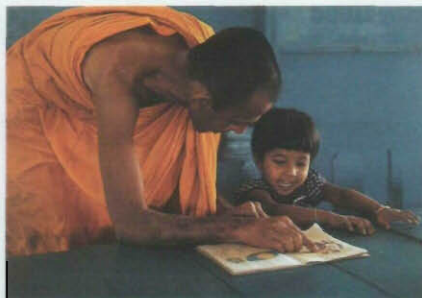
Sri Lanka's capital and chief port, Colombo, was developed by the Portuguese after 1507. The commercial capital is at Fort, so-called as it was a military garrison during Portuguese and Dutch occupation from the 16th to the 18th centuries. Today's city has a population of 2,241,000. It is a blend of old and modern buildings, with a busy bazaar area known as the Pettah. There are also Buddhist and Hindu temples and mosques.



The Fort

The Sacred Tooth

At the heart of Sri Lanka is the Buddhist holy city of Kandy, with a population of more than 100,000. There, in a gold casket inside the Dalada Maligawa (Temple of the Tooth), is a tooth that is said to have come from Buddha's funeral pyre (fire) in 486 BC. Every August, in the grand Perahera procession, the tooth casket is paraded on the back of a sumptuously decorated elephant.



Education

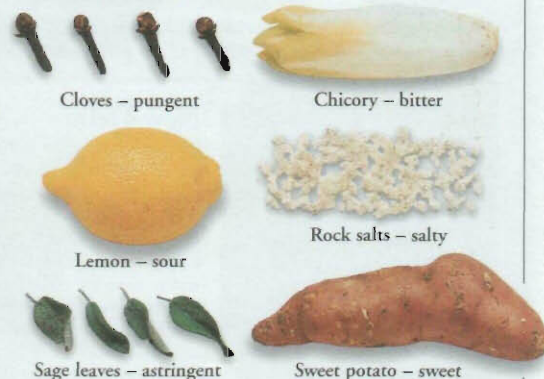
At 92 per cent, Sri Lanka has one of the highest Asian literacy rates. It has nearly 19,000 schools and 12 universities, including an Open University. Begun in 1980, it was modelled on the British Open University, a self-instructional learning scheme, aided by television, recordings, and mailed course materials.

Buddha figure carved from sapphire.



Gemstones

Sri Lanka produces brilliant gemstones, which are found near Ratnapura, the "City of Gems", which lies southeast of Colombo. It is especially noted for its sapphires. Other gems include deep yellow topazes, large rubies, and amethysts. Many are made into jewellery.



Cloves – pungent

Chicory – bitter

Lemon – sour

Rock salts – salty

Sage leaves – astringent

Sweet potato – sweet

Farming

Most Sri Lankans live in the humid southeast of the island. About 38 per cent are poor farmers growing rice, sugar-cane, cassava, and sweet potatoes for their own consumption, or working on plantations producing tea, rubber, and coconuts for export. Nearly 30 per cent of the land is used for crops, and almost seven per cent for grazing cattle, buffaloes, and goats.

Rice

Coconut

Tea

Sri Lanka is the world's largest tea exporter. The tea is still marketed abroad as Ceylon tea. There are more than 2,000 tea estates. Their teas are described as high-grown, medium-grown, or low-grown, according to their height above sea-level. The best quality comes from the cooler climate of the central highlands. The tea is hand picked, mostly by women, to preserve the delicate leaves. The pickers are paid by the basketful.



Dried tea leaves

Tea leaves

Ayurvedic medicine

The traditional Hindu form of medicine called Ayurvedic medicine is practised throughout Sri Lanka. Its name comes from the Ayurveda, an ancient treatise on healing that divides foods into six tastes. A healthy diet combines all of these. Ill-health can be cured by adjusting their intake. Sri Lanka also has an extensive national health service.



Tourism

Despite the civil war, Sri Lanka's tourist industry is beginning to flourish. Increasing numbers of Europeans in search of winter sun visit the island's beautiful palm-shaded sandy beaches and coral reefs. Buddhists from all over the world make pilgrimages to the sacred Buddhist city of Kandy.